

Checklist:

The Right Processes

1. Steps for Identifying the Key Customer Outcome

- ☐ Bring executives together to define the key customer outcome.
- ☐ Ask: “**How do customers know this product is delivering value?**”
- ☐ Treat each answer as a hypothesis, not a decision.
- ☐ Conduct customer research to validate or reject the hypotheses.
- ☐ Use the **5 Whys** to uncover the real customer need.
- ☐ Combine qualitative and quantitative data.
- ☐ Consider future customers, prospects, and market trends.
- ☐ Identify the final decision-maker.
- ☐ Define different outcomes for different customer segments or personas.
- ☐ Document the assumptions, options considered, and rationale.
- ☐ Get alignment from the CEO/founder and executive team.
- ☐ Create outcome pyramids from both the customer and company perspective.
- ☐ Define usage metrics that act as leading indicators of success.

2. Steps for Crafting the Customer Journey Vision

- ☐ Validate the customer outcome with forward-thinking customers.
- ☐ Seek external validation before relying on internal opinions.
- ☐ Gather input from customer-facing teams:
 - ☐ Sales
 - ☐ Marketing
 - ☐ Customer support
 - ☐ Account management
- ☐ Gather input from engineering leadership on feasibility, risks, and complexity.
- ☐ Review third-party sources such as app reviews, communities, industry reports, and review sites.
- ☐ Map the full customer journey:

- ☐ Trigger
- ☐ Discovery
- ☐ Evaluation
- ☐ Trial
- ☐ Engagement
- ☐ Retention
- ☐ Draft the journey vision before asking everyone to create separate versions.
- ☐ Share an early version with stakeholders, customers, and prospects.
- ☐ Collect feedback and revise.
- ☐ Watch for weak consensus or groupthink.
- ☐ Strengthen the vision until it is clear, valuable, realistic, and inspiring.

3. Steps for Crafting the Product Strategy

- ☐ Hold a cross-functional strategy session.
- ☐ Include product, design, engineering, marketing, sales, and customer success.
- ☐ Share customer research before the meeting.
- ☐ Ask participants to prepare ideas in advance.
- ☐ Make the session a discussion, not a presentation.
- ☐ Identify major disagreements or disconnects.
- ☐ Clarify whether disagreements are about:
 - ☐ Risk tolerance
 - ☐ Market direction
 - ☐ Competitive threats
 - ☐ Technical feasibility
 - ☐ Customer needs
- ☐ Agree on the decision-making process before forcing agreement on the decision.
- ☐ Treat stakeholders as advisors and contributors, not voters.
- ☐ Make the CEO or empowered product leader the final decision-maker.
- ☐ Use an offsite or neutral setting when possible.
- ☐ Give the meeting enough time for real discussion.
- ☐ Call out assumptions, risks, pivot points, and open questions.
- ☐ Define success milestones and reassessment milestones.

4. Steps for Communicating the Outcome, Vision, and Strategy

- ☐ Prepare a clear story, not just a presentation.
- ☐ Practice the presentation before sharing broadly.
- ☐ Anticipate likely questions and objections.
- ☐ Use customer evidence to support the message.
- ☐ Consider letting customers “speak” through recordings, quotes, or interview clips.
- ☐ Explain the key outcome, customer journey, and strategy in plain language.
- ☐ Make the vision exciting and credible.
- ☐ Communicate that the strategy is a living document.
- ☐ Set expectations that reassessment and adjustment will happen over time.

5. Processes for Maintaining Ongoing Customer Validation

- ☐ Build a regular customer discovery habit.
- ☐ Continuously test assumptions in the vision and strategy.
- ☐ Use customer research before deciding what to build, not only after work is prioritized.
- ☐ Use multiple research methods:
 - ☐ Market research
 - ☐ Persona research
 - ☐ Card sorting
 - ☐ Diary studies
 - ☐ Customer advisory boards
 - ☐ Win/loss analysis
 - ☐ Surveys
 - ☐ Interviews
 - ☐ Usability studies
- ☐ Spend at least four hours per week on customer research when possible.
- ☐ Hire a dedicated customer research specialist once the product team is large enough.
- ☐ Regularly talk to customers even when there is no immediate project.

6. Processes for Tracking Iteration and Product Outcomes

- ☐ Define metrics that show whether product changes are delivering value.
- ☐ Track customer behavior, not just output.

- ☐ Use quantitative feedback loops to guide iteration.
- ☐ Choose durable metrics that reflect value for multiple stakeholders.
- ☐ Run experiments or A/B tests where appropriate.
- ☐ Use results to adjust product direction.

7. Processes for Reassessing the Roadmap and Vision

- ☐ Reassess the roadmap and vision at the one-third or one-quarter mark of the total time horizon.
- ☐ For a one-year roadmap, update it quarterly.
- ☐ For a three-year vision, update it at least once a year.
- ☐ Revisit strategy after major milestones.
- ☐ Watch for market changes, competitors, regulations, or customer shifts.
- ☐ Change direction when evidence shows the current strategy is no longer correct.

8. Processes for Handling Inbound Product Requests

- ☐ Create a process for managing feature requests and ideas.
- ☐ Avoid saying yes to every stakeholder request.
- ☐ Maintain an idea bank for suggestions, including ideas not on the roadmap.
- ☐ Be transparent about what is on the roadmap and what is not.
- ☐ Explain why certain ideas do not make the roadmap.
- ☐ Use a consistent prioritization framework such as RICE.
- ☐ Regularly review ideas, scores, and rankings.
- ☐ Share updates with stakeholders who submitted ideas.
- ☐ Ask stakeholders for their top 1–2 priorities, not a long wish list.
- ☐ Ask why they prioritized those items.

9. Processes for Collecting Roadmap Input by Stakeholder Group

- ☐ Ask founders/CEO about strategic milestones, market trends, and technical stability.
- ☐ Ask finance about investment horizons, efficiency, and the trade-off between growth and profitability.

- ☐ Ask sales about customer needs, deal blockers, and prospect concerns.
- ☐ Ask marketing about market trends, pipeline growth, and automatable tasks.
- ☐ Ask customer success about retention, customer outcomes, and support needs.
- ☐ Ask engineering about technical opportunities, performance, tech debt, and scalability.
- ☐ Ask design about UX issues, customer outcomes, and workflow constraints.

10. Processes for Balancing the Roadmap

- ☐ Categorize roadmap items into:
 - ☐ Innovation
 - ☐ Iteration
 - ☐ Operation
 - ☐ Define an allocation target for each category.
 - ☐ Tag roadmap items by category.
 - ☐ Check whether investment is balanced appropriately.
 - ☐ Adjust allocation when one category is over- or underfunded.
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11. Processes for Building and Executing the Product Backlog

- ☐ Do not assume the product backlog appears automatically from strategy.
- ☐ Use vision and strategic planning to feed innovation work.
- ☐ Use customer feedback, new features, and A/B testing to feed iteration work.
- ☐ Use bugs, internal tools, and technical improvements to feed operations work.
- ☐ Prioritize each category intentionally.
- ☐ Convert roadmap priorities into sprint-ready backlog items.
- ☐ Work with engineering to plan delivery.

12. Processes for Creating the Roadmap Document

- ☐ Make clear which initiatives belong to innovation, iteration, or operation.
- ☐ Show allocation targets when possible.
- ☐ Paint a picture far enough into the future for other teams to plan.
- ☐ Explain the rationale behind the work.

- ☐ Focus on problems, value, and outcomes, not just features.
- ☐ Leave room for plans to change.
- ☐ Avoid false precision.
- ☐ Avoid giving every roadmap item the same level of detail.
- ☐ Avoid feature-date commitments unless there is a strong business reason.
- ☐ Avoid forcing too many items into the roadmap.

13. Communicating the Roadmap Internally

- ☐ Share the roadmap with executives first.
- ☐ Present the roadmap to major groups separately:
 - ☐ Engineering, QA, and architecture
 - ☐ Sales and marketing
 - ☐ Account management, customer success, and support
 - ☐ HR, finance, and other teams
- ☐ Tailor the message to each group's needs.
- ☐ Give people space to ask questions.
- ☐ Use surveys or anonymous feedback channels after presentations.

14. Communicating the Roadmap Externally Carefully

- ☐ Avoid sharing the internal roadmap with customers or sales prospects.
- ☐ Share broad themes rather than detailed commitments.
- ☐ Avoid specific dates unless absolutely necessary.
- ☐ Add buffers when discussing future plans.
- ☐ Preserve flexibility for product discovery and Agile development.
- ☐ Minimize detail and avoid overpromising.

15. Choosing the Right Development Process

- ☐ Use innovation sprints for bold, future-facing work.
- ☐ Consider longer cycles for innovation work when teams need space to think deeply.
- ☐ Use Scrum for iteration, experimentation, and build-measure-learn loops.

- ☐ Use Kanban for operational issues, production problems, bugs, and urgent technical work.
- ☐ Match the process to the type of work rather than forcing one method on everything.

16. Assessing Product Development Efficiency

- ☐ Measure progress against roadmap completion, not just story points.
- ☐ Track whether shipped work produced the intended outcome.
- ☐ Ask product managers to show evidence after releases.
- ☐ Review whether launches moved the intended metric or created the desired value.
- ☐ Share evidence with engineering so teams see the impact of their work.
- ☐ Conduct this type of outcome review at least quarterly.

17. Creating and Managing the Product Metrics Dashboard

- ☐ Create a dashboard showing key customer and company outcome metrics.
- ☐ Keep the dashboard simple.
- ☐ Track only a few meaningful metrics tied to the outcome pyramid.
- ☐ Update the dashboard daily where possible.
- ☐ Add temporary launch metrics when needed.
- ☐ Remove temporary metrics after their purpose is complete.
- ☐ Expose the dashboard internally.
- ☐ Review metrics regularly with the organization.
- ☐ Connect team efforts to business and customer outcomes.